

Deontological and Consequentialist thinking in regards to Social media.

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COR-204-08: Theoretical Perspectives - Spring 2024 (2024SP)

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3/27/24

Section 1: Overview or the topic:

Humans as a species, over the last thousand years, have made so many technological advancements that it has become paramount to answer the question of whether our advancements are ethical. The scope of our reach, and by extension our social power as individuals. We as individuals hold so much power over others lives and by extension we must contemplate the ethicality of our actions on social media. In this paper we will be discussing the ethicality of donations, personas, comments, and negligence from both a consequentialist and deontological standpoint. Given that the scope of social media as a whole is too large to cover in totality we will only be discussing the actions of the individual and its direct relevance to the occurrences that occur around it.

Before we begin, we must first come to terms with some definitions and central themes of this paper. So, what is Deontology? Deontology is an ethical theory created by Kant with the purpose of structuring one's action to remain moral. The main theories being that of the Categorical and Practical Imperative. Below you can find the structure to each imperative and its use cases. The Categorical Imperative, colloquially referred to as the universalizability principle, goes as follows

“Act only on that maxim through which you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law without contradiction.” (Kant).

To help you understand what this means, let's break it down. A maxim is simply the action one must take in order to obtain the value of X. Let's say a starving man enters a bakery and sees that the baker is engrossed in his work and is not aware of his presence. Sitting atop the case is a freshly cooked batch of bread. If the starving man decided to take a piece of bread then his Maxim would be to steal. As such his universal law would be that of: "I will that all men should steal all the time". This by nature is an impossible law as it would remove human agency, the thing that makes all rational agents rational.

The next Imperative we must discuss is that of the practical imperative, colloquially referred to as the formula of humanity, which says the following.

"Act so that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or in that of another, always as an end, and never merely as a means." (Kant).

Now that we have the definition let's break this down into a more manageable and understandable statement. To treat something as merely a means would be to only care about oneself in a situation and to not care if your actions negatively affect others, be it their wants or their physicality. As such we can deduce that Kant is stating the following. "Rational beings must never use themselves or others without regard for each party's well being and overarching goals." For example, your boss is constantly

mocking a coworker of yours for doing the bare minimum associated with the job. You really want to get a raise and so you decide to mock the individual with your boss in order to get on their good side. This would be unethical because you, by mocking your coworker, are treating your coworker as merely a means to your end goal.

Finally Consequentialism is a theory written about by an Ethical philosopher named John Stuart Mill in 1863. The general concept between this consequentialist utilitarian theory is that to remain ethical you must take into account all pleasure and or pain caused by your decision. Pleasure being the moral good and pain being the moral negative. So for example if a multi-million dollar corporation was working based on the hard physical and mental labor of its employees without adequate payment for employees, then that would be negative. For the pain associated with the job is not worth the money being given to the employees for their work.

Section 2: The Ethics of Online Personas:

Social Media is a medium for entertainment and social commentary which allows for individuals to highlight specific character traits be it of themselves or of others. These specified character traits ultimately lead to the manifestation of an online persona. To be specific a persona consists of aspects of their personal nature that they may or may not show to others (Collins). Ultimately online personas are used to highlight either the best or worst of your personality, depending on the context of the social

media platforms you are using. This is morally questionable under the context of Deontology, for you by withholding information are essentially lying to the other party. And to lie is to remove another individual's opportunity for rational decision making. Rationality being the main component which makes individuals moral and different from the animals that walk around us (Kant). Through the creation of an online persona individuals are able to place their actions upon the persona, and or façade, they have created. Depending on the context of the situation this could lead to backstabbing and or individuals to spout harmful content (Hagar). This by proxy would only be a negative when looked at through the lens of deontology.

When looking at the concept of personas through the lens of consequentialism we end up coming to a conundrum. The conundrum being how far we must look to remain moral. The concept of persona's makes us ask, what are the unintended consequences of our posts and are said consequences equal to the pleasure experienced by them (Mill). Given the vast scope of social media it could be argued that infinite amounts of consequences may occur. Some examples include, social contagion, increases in groupthink, and increases in depression and anxiety due to underlying mental health issues (Connor). On the other hand social media can lead to the formation of larger friend groups. It can allow for cross-continental communication, and if used properly can help mitigate the damage dealt by the loss of third party spaces (Bekalu).

Given that the vast majority of social media users are GenZ, approximately 31% (Orbelo), and GenZ has been found to have higher levels of loneliness than previous generations, it could be said that the online third party space is an area that allows for furthering connections (Trinko).

My specific opinion on the use of personas from a consequentialist lens is that they ultimately fail their purpose. Humans are social creatures and by putting on a front and showing off only the best or worst, you will never truly feel seen. Ultimately persona could be a consequential nightmare as only seeing the best of others life leads individuals to depression and by proxy has led the suicide rate to climbing as well. ([CDC](#)). Thus the individual onlookers pain outweighs the pleasures associated. As such if individuals are to use social media then they must show themselves for who they are; The Best, The Worst, and The Ugly.

Section 3: Disinformation and Mis-Attribution of Pleasure:

For this section of the paper I will mostly be talking about disinformation. To talk about misinformation would simply be outside of the ethical scope of this paper. This is because we will be talking about disinformation in social media based advertising. Social media based advertising is an ethical issue for both the sponsor and the individual who posted their sponsorship. The reason this is necessary to discuss is because not all sponsors do what they say they do. To begin, let's discuss the Children's

Wish Foundation International. The CWFI is a foundation dedicated to the purpose of bringing children's wishes true. However over a span of ten years only 11% of the money raised, 96.8 million, was actually given to the children. Now you may be asking where did the rest of the money meant for the children go? The answer, while tragic, is obvious. The money that was missing was egregiously claimed by the executive director of the charities foundation (Reynolds, 2013). Those that donated to the cause as well as the children were simply seen as a means to an end by the executive director. Her actions were immoral because she lied. (Kant). We can also say this was unethical because her decision to take so much money led to less pleasure being put out into the world. Not all of the children were given their wishes and some likely could have been saved with the money she took. (Mill, 1863). Anyone paid to provide social media sponsorship from this organization would have behaved immorally through consequentialist ethics but, they may not have behaved immorally through deontological ethics. For they themselves were robbed of rationality through the lies fed by the multimillion dollar non-profit organization.

Consequentialist ethics however do allow for individuals to lie and or deceive depending on the motivation for it and its ultimate outcomes. As such if disinformation ultimately leads to pleasure for the majority it would not be seen as unethical. If you are interested in how consequentialism can be taken advantage of I would suggest looking into the ministry of truth from the book 1984 by George Orwell.

Section 4: The pitfalls of media consumption:

For this point we will be discussing a Chinese influencer known as Luo Xiao Mao Mao Zi. After losing two boyfriends, one of which she made famous, she became heavily depressed. Over time her videos slowly started to falter as a result until she came to her final video. In this video she stated “I appear to be happy, but this is all for show. I hope everyone will be happy when they see my videos and will see that I am happy too. [But] I can’t hold on anymore,” (Luo Xiao Mao Mao Zi). She then asked her chat if she should drink pesticide and the response was sickeningly flooded by individuals egging her on. She did and by the next day her life had been cut (Chan, 2020). While this may seem like an edge case, we must discuss the worst if we are to understand the potential consequences of social media addiction. Morally, Luo Xiao Mao Mao Zi acted unethically because to kill oneself goes against one's value as a rational being and as such is morally reprehensible. She treated herself as nothing more than a means. Those in the crowd who egged her on acted immorally because they treated Xiao simply as a means to their entertainment while not caring about what the end result would be. They were either too interested in their own pleasure or they were too invested in seeing harm come to Xiao. The only ones who can be said to have remained ethical would be those who told her not too (Kant). However as the old saying goes, the squeaky wheels get the grease. Another less polarizing example of this concept would be challenges such as the tide pod challenge. The reason why this is similar is because it leads to individuals experiencing damage to their esophagus. This led to blood pressure changes, internal burns,

gastrointestinal issues, and neurological symptoms such as the loss of consciousness (ABC). The downstream effects caused by this simply result in pain for the majority. Thus it can not be said to be ethical (Mill).

The main value that is added to individuals' lives of all is the ability to remain interconnected with others regardless of the distance one must travel to get to that point. A large network of communication allows for the flow of information that is necessary to mitigate bias allowing for individuals to act in a more rational manner. In that way I believe Kant would approve of Social media. The same would apply to the consequentialist as well. The internet allows for a large amount of pleasure to be gained from improving oneself however, that is only if that is the goal of the individual. In essence social media allows for the most good for the most people but, only if individuals use it ethically. (Mill)

Section 5: Final thoughts:

In the end social media is a tool, and as such, it cannot be unethical. The use of said tool can be however. As we have seen in regards to the massive amounts of negative self-ideation, mental stagnation, negative media curation and even, Disinformation as a whole. For if individuals only act within themselves for themselves then they may never be able to act ethically. For only when one acts on the behest of others can one say that they have created the greatest pleasure.

Regardless of the negative effects, social media has allowed individuals to improve themselves and has allowed for individuals to stay in touch which both are seen positively. My main suggestion for you, the reader, would be to monitor the amount of time you spend on social media. Social media, while an amazing tool, should simply be used as a tool. We must see the humanity in those who post but we must also recognize that not everyone remains ethical online and as such we need to remain vigilant.

Humans were never supposed to have such long-range and overarching forms of communication. However, now that we have them, we should use them to add to people's lives rather than subtract. We must see others, be they future or present, never merely as a means and always an end in and of themselves. In this way we may behave ethically by both consequentialist and Deontological theory.

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